

Ahmedabad Public Library Network

IFLA-aligned comparator report: M.J. Library and Toronto Public Library

2026-06-13

Table of contents

What This Report Measures	1
Executive Findings	1
IFLA-Aligned Comparator	2
Ahmedabad Trend	3
Finance and User Fees	3
PPP Finance Context	4
Data Gaps	4
Ward-Level Gap Queue	4
Working Conclusions	5
Source Base	5

! Core finding

On the IFLA Library Map of the World metric frame, Ahmedabad's M.J. Library network is weak on service-point density and extremely weak on registered users and loans. The cleanest headline is **one registered M.J. Library network member per roughly 264 Ahmedabad residents.**

What This Report Measures

This report uses IFLA's Library Map of the World framing as the primary comparator standard. IFLA's Data Lab is built around core statistics such as service points, registered users, physical visits, physical loans, eBook loans, audio book loans, downloads, staff, volunteers, and internet access. IFLA also supports per-1-million population views, which is the right denominator for city comparison.

Finance is still included, but only as a secondary context. PPP dollars do not measure library performance; they help interpret the scale of public commitment behind the service.

Executive Findings

Ahmedabad's M.J. Library network looks less like a citywide public reading system and more like a flagship collection and institutional archive with weak active-use conversion.

Latest M.J. Library disclosure data for 2025-26 reports:

Measure	Value
Collection items	811,093
New additions	4,859

Measure	Value
Registered network members	26,834
Annual members	505
Lifetime members	25,574
Gyanvihar members	755
Annual circulation	96,491
Collection refresh	0.60%

Against the SevenT4 Ahmedabad ward-population denominator of 7,078,533 residents, that is only 0.379 percent registered membership penetration.

The financing is overwhelmingly municipal. In 2025-26, M.J. Library reports a budget of Rs 22.7675 crore, of which Rs 21.9255 crore is AMC grant and Rs 0.8420 crore is library income. AMC therefore funds 96.30 percent of the reported budget.

Metric status summary

Metric category	Value	Confidence	Status
Registered membership penetration	0.379%	High	Low reach
Residents per registered member	263.8	High	Access gap
Annual circulation	96,491	High	Critical decline
Collection refresh	0.60%	High	Slow renewal

Data confidence is high where values are directly reported or arithmetically derived from reported values. Missing IFLA fields are not inferred; they are reported as explicit data gaps.

IFLA-Aligned Comparator

IFLA metric	Ahmedabad / M.J. Library	Toronto Public Library	Reading
Service points per 1M residents	8.8 using 62 AMC library points	34.0-36.5 using 100 branches + 2 bookmobiles	Toronto has about 4x the service-point density.
Registered users per 1M residents	3,790.9	Not published on current TPL page	Ahmedabad's registered-user base is extremely low.
New registrations per 1M residents	71.3 annual M.J. members	78,423-84,195 card registrations	TPL's annual registration flow is over 1,000x larger per resident.
Physical visits per 1M residents	No disclosed visit count	4.47m-4.80m branch visits	Ahmedabad cannot yet be compared on this IFLA metric.
Loans per 1M residents	13,631.5 circulation	9.33m-10.02m borrowings	TPL records roughly 685x more borrowing per resident.
eBook/audio/download metrics	Not captured	Not separated on current TPL page	Add to next extraction schema.

IFLA metric	Ahmedabad / M.J. Library	Toronto Public Library	Reading
Staff, volunteers, internet access	Not captured	Not counted on current TPL page	Add to next extraction schema.

The strongest standard metric is loans per population. Ahmedabad reports 13,631.5 circulations per million residents. Toronto reports 9.33-10.02 million borrowings per million residents. The Toronto figure is all material borrowing rather than a physical-only IFLA line, but the gap is too large to be explained by classification alone.

The second strongest standard metric is service points per population. Ahmedabad has 8.8 service points per million residents using the authoritative AMC library layer. Toronto has 34.0-36.5 per million when branches and bookmobiles are counted as service points. Ahmedabad's physical access footprint is about one quarter of Toronto's on this denominator.

Ahmedabad Trend

Membership growth needs a careful reading. The headline network member count rose from 20,764 in 2015-16 to 26,834 in 2025-26, a 29.2 percent increase. But annual members peaked at 3,194 in 2018-19 and fell to 505 by 2025-26. The 2025-26 membership base is therefore lifetime-heavy: lifetime members account for about 95 percent of the network roll.

Circulation is the clearest demand-capture warning. The network reported 193,138 circulations in 2015-16, 207,360 in 2016-17, and 212,397 in 2017-18. By 2025-26, it reported 96,491. Reported circulation has roughly halved from the pre-2020 level.

Finance and User Fees

M.J. Library's 2025-26 budget table reports:

Finance line	Rs crore	Share
Total budget	22.7675	100.00%
AMC grant	21.9255	96.30%
Library income	0.8420	3.70%
Books	0.2500	1.10% of total budget
All reading material	0.3275	1.44% of total budget
Establishment/payroll	14.0415	61.67% of total budget
Maintenance	1.5550	6.83% of total budget
IT automation	0.7600	3.34% of total budget
Capital	1.5800	6.94% of total budget
New plans	2.7100	11.90% of total budget

The "library income" line should not be treated as pure user-fee revenue. It is an upper bound for self-income and may include membership fees, reading-room charges, auditorium rent, deposits, fines, interest, and miscellaneous receipts.

Even a generous 2025-26 membership-fee estimate comes to about Rs 17.335 lakh, or 0.761 percent of total budget and 20.6 percent of disclosed library income. Fees therefore do not fund the library. Their practical role is closer to access rationing and administrative filtering inside a system already paid for by AMC.

PPP Finance Context

PPP conversion uses the World Bank PA.NUS.PPP indicator:

Country	Conversion factor used	Interpretation
India	Rs 20.4219876 per international dollar	Latest checked value available for India was 2024; used for M.J. Library 2025-26.
Canada	CAD 1.150472 per international dollar	2024 value; matched to TPL's 2024 finance and usage data.

Supplemental finance comparison:

Metric	Ahmedabad / M.J. Library	Toronto Public Library
Public budget, PPP	\$11.15m intl.	\$254.7m intl.
Budget per resident, PPP	\$1.57	\$85-\$91
Budget per borrow, PPP	\$115.5	\$9.1

Toronto spends roughly 54x more per resident in PPP terms. But it also records roughly 685x more borrowing per resident. That means Ahmedabad's problem is not only underfunding; it is also weak conversion of public subsidy and collection stock into visible public use.

Data Gaps

The M.J. Library disclosures do not yet expose several IFLA metrics in a clean standard format:

- physical visits;
- eBook loans;
- audio book loans;
- downloads;
- libraries with internet access;
- full-time staff;
- volunteers.

The next extraction schema should add these fields explicitly: `ifla_metric_name`, `ifla_metric_scope`, `metric_value`, `population_denominator`, `per_1m_population`, `source_page`, and `confidence`.

Ward-Level Gap Queue

The dashboard draft identified the next spatial-analysis queue rather than a completed catchment result. The priority is to join library locations to bus, BRTS, metro, schools and colleges, population density, and ward deprivation, then classify high-population wards with weak library catchment access.

Initial priority candidates to test:

Ward candidate	Priority	Why it is queued
Lambha	High	Very high population and previous service-gap signals.

Ward candidate	Priority	Why it is queued
Ramol Hathijan	High	Very high population and previous service-gap signals.
Vastral	High	High population with weak public-library access signals.

These are queued candidates, not final catchment findings. The final ward-gap table should only be published after the spatial join is run and source confidence is attached to each ward row.

Working Conclusions

1. M.J. Library is important, but the data makes it look like a flagship-plus-archive institution more than a citywide public reading network.
2. The membership number is not an active-user number. It is lifetime-heavy and should be reported alongside annual members, new members, renewals, and active borrowers.
3. AMC grant dependence is not a weakness by itself. Public libraries are public goods. The weakness is that a 96 percent public-funded network has such low public reach.
4. User fees are fiscally marginal and socially material. They do not fund the library, but they can still deter use.
5. Ward/catchment analysis should be the next step, beginning with Lambha, Ramol Hathijan, and Vastral as high-priority candidates for verification.

Source Base

- IFLA Library Map of the World, About library data: <https://librarymap.ifla.org/about-library-data>
- IFLA Library Map of the World, Data Lab: <https://librarymap.ifla.org/datalab>
- IFLA Repository, Library Map of the World Data Definitions: <https://repository.ifla.org/handle/20.500.14598/3958>
- M.J. Library 2025-26 proactive disclosure: https://www.mjlibrary.in/assets/img/pdf/mj_discloser_rti_2025-26.pdf
- Toronto Public Library, About the Library: <https://tpl.ca/about-the-library/>
- Toronto Public Library, 2024 Finance Reports: <https://tpl.ca/about-the-library/library-finance/reports/2024-2/>
- World Bank PPP conversion factor, GDP, PA.NUS.PPP: <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/PA.NUS.PPP>